Parshas Ha'azinu

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The Lamplighter

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Parsha Insights

What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

Candle Lighting Times*

Greater Toronto Area

Light Candles	7:04 PM
Shabbos Ends	8:03 PM

Do You Love to "Hate" Sukkot?

By Menachem Posner

Some people love to hate Sukkot.

We boast to our friends about the great pains we go through to build the biggest, strongest and most beautiful sukkah the world has ever seen.

We love to kvetch about the difficulty of planning outdoor meals when the heavens may gift us with steamy sunshine, torrents of rain, a sprinkling of early snow, or any combination thereof.

We complain about the inconvenience of having to drag a three-course dinner out to the backyard and how little we like pine needles in our soup.

We can go on and on about how hard it is to have yet another Jewish holiday coming so close to Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. We have had enough round challah in honey, don't want to look at another pan of potato kugel, and can't bear the sight of yet another bowl of sushi salad.



Of course we deeply love the holiday, its mitzvahs, and the many opportunities it provides us to bond with family, enrich our appreciation of our tradition, and strengthen our connection to G-d.

But still, do the Jewish holidays need to be so intense? Why do they need to be so labor-intensive and (pardon me for mentioning it) expensive?

That's right. Religious Jews spend many thousands of dollars on lulav and etrog sets, fresh greenery to cover the sukkah, outfits for the kids, and food—oy, the food!

Yes, the holidays can be celebrated on a shoestring budget, but for some reason, we feel compelled to go all out, spending just a bit more than we can afford and investing more energy than we knew we had.

For some this entails inviting just one more family, and for others it may mean purchasing the ingredients to make a little extra something to honor the holiday.

G-d Himself knows that we Jews are spread across the financial spectrum, from wealthy to comfortable to just-getting-by to living paycheck-to-paycheck and deeply in debt.

Yet we all go out of our way to honor Him and celebrate His holidays with joy.

This leads me to something I've heard from my grandfather more than a dozen times.

Having passed the 90-year marker, Zaydie has seen a lot.

He remembers the time when chalav Yisrael milk (milk that has been supervised by a Jew from the time of milking) in New York needed to be brought from the farm, when there wasn't a single kosher bakery in Los Angeles, and people fully expected American Orthodox Jewry to fade away with the "greenhorns" who lovingly carried it over the ocean from the Old Country.

Yet the pioneering men and women of his generation successfully raised their children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren to treasure Judaism and live its ideals.

When they were children, they were scorned by their neighbors, teachers, and friends for clinging to the old-fashioned ways of the shtetl. "America is a great melting pot," they were told by their Yiddish-accented elders, "blend in and lose yourself."

But, inspired by the example of the Sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe, who had come to America from war-torn Europe in 1940, Zaydie and his friends proudly embraced Judaism, at home and on the street.

When observing the tremendous growth of Jewish life in America, Zaydie often points to a verse in this week's Torah portion: "And Jeshurun became fat and rebelled." Despite the bounty G-d gave them, our ancestors chose to rebel. The verse highlights the direct line that often extends from material success to moral denigration.

"I take issue with this verse," Zaydie likes to

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Parsha in a Nutshell

Parshas Ha'azinu

The name of the Parshah, "Ha'azinu," means "Listen" and it is found in Deuteronomy 32:1.

The greater part of the Torah reading of Haazinu ("Listen In") consists of a 70-line "song" delivered by Moses to the people of Israel on the last day of his earthly life.

Calling heaven and earth as witnesses, Moses exhorts the people, "Remember the days of old / Consider the years of many generations / Ask your father, and he will recount it to you / Your elders, and they will tell you" how G-d "found them in a desert land," made them a people, chose them as His own, and bequeathed them a bountiful land. The song also warns against the pitfalls of plenty—"Yeshurun grew fat and kicked / You have grown fat, thick and rotund / He forsook G-d who made him / And spurned the Rock of his salvation"—and the terrible calamities that would result, which Moses describes as G-d "hiding His face." Yet in the end, he promises, G-d will avenge the blood of His servants, and be reconciled with His people and land.

The Parshah concludes with G-d's instruction to Moses to ascend the summit of Mount Nebo, from which he will behold the Promised Land before dying on the mountain. "For you shall see the land opposite you; but you shall not go there, into the land which I give to the children of Israel."

Food For Thought

Yom Kippur is a day of forgiveness for those who return.

But then, every day is a day of forgiveness for those who return.

Yet Yom Kippur is an entirely different story.

Because on any other day when a soul returns, her misdeeds are discarded.

On Yom Kippur, when a soul returns, she is held in tight embrace.

Within the fire of that embrace, there never were any misdeeds. There is only oneness, peace, and eternal love.

Your thoughts on the Lamplighter matter!
Tell us what you like and how we can improve it.

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say. "I look around and see what Jews do with the riches America has given them. They buy glatt kosher food, they send their kids to top-notch Torah day schools, and they celebrate His holidays with lavishness. Walk into a kosher grocery store and see shelves of products we never dreamed of."

Instead of using our riches to rebel, we use them to serve G-d in the best way possible. We've broken the mold.

Now, he concludes prayerfully, it's time for G-d to do likewise. Our parshah is replete with verses foretelling the suffering that will be heaped upon our people as a result of our insubordination. Our request is that He break away from the promises of suffering and difficulty and replace them with joy, tranquility, and redemption.

We've passed the test; now it's time for the test to pass us.

Jewish Matters

Upcoming Highlights & History

We find ourselves now in the Ten Days of Repentance, the ten-day period from Rosh Hashanah to Yom Kippur, of which the prophet speaks (Isaiah 55:6): "Seek G-d when He is to be found; call on Him when He is near."

Sat, Sep 19 · 8 Tishrei

The 14-day dedication festivities for the First Temple, built by King Solomon, began on 8 Tishrei 2935. The Temple served as the center of Jewish national and spiritual life for 410 years until its destruction by the Babylonians in 423 BCE.

The Shabbat between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur is called Shabbat Shuvah, "Shabbat of Return." The name derives from the Haftarah for this Shabbat, which opens with the words (Hosea 14:2), "Return O Israel unto the L-rd your G-d..." Occurring in the Ten Days of Repentance, it is a most auspicious time to rectify the failings and missed opportunities of the past and positively influence the coming year.

The master Kabbalist Rabbi Isaac Luria taught that the seven days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur correspond to the seven days of the week – the Sunday embodies all Sundays of the year, the Monday all Mondays, and so on. Shabbat Shuvah is thus the archetypal Shabbat, empowering us to influence every Shabbat of the year.

Mon, Sep 21 · 10 Tishrei

On this date in the year 2449, 82 days after the Golden Calf and two 40-day periods of Moses pleading on Sinai, G-d "restored His goodwill with the Jewish people gladly and wholeheartedly," saying "I have forgiven, as you ask," and gave Moses the Second Tablets – establishing the day as one of atonement and forgiveness for all generations.

The prophet Ezekiel saw a vision of being transported to the Temple Mount, where an angel with a measuring rod gave him a detailed tour of the Third Temple (Ezekiel 40:1).

Thu, Sep 24 · 13 Tishrei

Yahrtzeit of Rabbi Shmuel Schneersohn, the fourth Chabad-Lubavitch Rebbe (known as the "Maharash") on 13 Tishrei 5643 (1882). Born in 1834, he succeeded his father as Rebbe in 1866. He authored more than 1,000 Chassidic discourses, was active in Jewish communal affairs, and advocated for Russian Jews facing pogroms. He passed away at age 48.

Sat, Oct 3 · 22 Tishrei

In 1977, while leading hakafot with thousands of chassidim in the main Chabad-Lubavitch synagogue in Brooklyn, the Rebbe suffered a massive heart attack but remained calm and continued the hakafot until they concluded. The next day, he asked that Simchat Torah be celebrated with its usual joy, and it was. After the holiday, he addressed anxious chassidim from his office, which had been converted into a cardiac unit. He remained under medical supervision for several weeks before returning home five weeks later, on 1 Kislev, a day now marked by chassidim as a day of celebration and thanksgiving.

At the close of the 14-day dedication festivities for the First Temple, "[King Solomon] sent off the people, and they blessed the king. They went to their homes, rejoicing and with glad hearts for all the good that the L-rd had wrought for David His servant and Israel His people" (I Kings 8:66).

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

Unpacking on the Battlefield

By Shimon Bekerman

My Story - with the - Rebbe



Having come from a family with chasidic roots, I gravitated to Lubavitch at a young age and studied in a Chabad yeshivah. But it was not until I was an adult and already married that I met the Rebbe. This was in 1965 when I traveled to New York to spend the Hebrew month of Tishrei – the month of the High Holidays and Sukkot – in his presence. At the end of my visit, I had a private audience and I confided in the Rebbe that, although I've been near him for several weeks already, I still didn't feel that a change has occurred in me, as I expected would happen.

In response, the Rebbe quoted a saying of his father-in-law, the Previous Rebbe, that "when you travel to the fair, you buy a lot of merchandise, pack it up and take it home, and you unpack the parcels all year." I understood what he meant – the one who travels to a fair is like the chasid who travels to his Rebbe for the month of Tishrei, "buying a lot of merchandise" – that is, acquiring spiritual inspiration. But he doesn't see what he has truly received until he gets home, processes it, and puts it into practice. And then he begins to feel that the Rebbe is with him all year long.

This proved very true for me, especially in later years, when the Yom Kippur War broke out.

The Yom Kippur War caught me, like all Israelis, in the midst of prayers on the holiest day of the year. I was praying at the yeshivah in Kfar Chabad, when I suddenly heard planes and saw cars out on the main street. I understood something terrible was happening, although I did not know exactly what until I returned home when Yom Kippur was over, and my wife told me that I had been ordered to report for duty. I immediately put on my uniform and wrote to the Rebbe that I was going off to war, asking for his blessing to return safely.

As I later learned, he immediately gave his blessing. And, in fact, my life was saved many times during the war. For example, as part of the IDF advance, I found myself on the Bir Gifgafa Airfield in the Sinai Desert. No sooner had my unit vacated the place than the Egyptians bombed it. But we managed to leave in time and were spared.

I tried my best to act as the Rebbe's emissary and, although it was virtually impossible, I tried to observe Sukkot in the Sinai and help others to do so as well. Together with a friend, I constructed a sukkah out of ammunition boxes, but we had to advance and we never managed to sit in it. I did not give up. Using some rope which I connected to a half-track jeep, I created a make-shift shelter and placed a few thorn-bush branches on top. In this sukkah, I made Kiddush, the blessing over wine, and there were about a hundred soldiers who heard that Kiddush.

On the night of Hoshana Rabbah we received an order to advance towards the Suez Canal. We participated in building a raft bridge that was used to cross the Canal and to conquer areas on the other side. A few hours after building the bridge and many Israeli vehicles passed to the Egyptian side, the Egyptians caught on to what was happening and started bombing us heavily, with missiles and rockets falling like rain. I jumped out of the car and took shelter under it, all the while reciting psalms that I remembered by heart.

Only in the morning, when I went to get my prayer shawl, did I see that a piece of shrapnel had penetrated my tallit and tefillin bag, but it had been stopped by a book of Selichot.

On the night of Simchat Torah, the bombings continued incessantly. My anti-craft unit had to go out the minute enemy planes were identified, and of course, this was very scary. Thank G-d we succeeded in bringing down quite a few planes, and we got a commendation medal for our efforts.

As soon as the bombings calmed down a bit, I went out to help soldiers put on tefillin. I did so for the entire time I was stationed in the Sinai – that is for about six months – until the Hebrew month of Adar. The soldiers had constructed an improvised synagogue out of sand sacks and tenting material, and when I would pass by on my way there, they would announce "Bekerman, tefillin!" and everyone would come out to put on tefillin.

One day during this time, Rabbi Israel Meir Lau, then the rabbi of North Tel Aviv, came to visit us, together with my brother-in-law, Rabbi Berke Wolf, who was the Chabad spokesman in Israel. It was a very emotional encounter – we hugged and kissed, and then he suddenly pulled out a letter from the Rebbe that was a response to the letter that I had written on the way to the war.

The Rebbe quoted the Torah: "Do not be faint-hearted, do not be afraid. Do not panic and do not be terrified of them." He went on to emphasize the importance of every soldier putting tefillin on his arm and head, binding his emotions and intellect to G-d. "This brings the blessing of G-d into the actions of his hands and his mind," he wrote.

He also expressed the hope that I should be able to report good news very soon, and that "the great merit of anyone who protects our Holy Land and our Holy Nation will hasten the fulfillment of the blessing that 'the Lord, your God is accompanying your camp to deliver you and to grant you victory over your enemy.'"

Rabbi Shimon Bekerman is a veteran activist and served as a member of Tzeirei Agudas Chabad in Israel. He was interviewed in his home in Kfar Chabad in June of 2014.

Yom Kippur

Yom Kippur, the holiest day of the year, begins before sunset on Sunday, September 20, 9 Tishrei. The 26-hour fast continues until nightfall Monday, September 21, 10 Tishrei. Kol Nidrei is recited at sunset. Those lighting a Yizkor candle should do so before lighting the holiday candles. Light Holiday Candles at 7:00 PM.

Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement: "For on this day He will forgive you, to purify you, that you be cleansed from all your sins before G-d" (Leviticus 16:30). For 26 hours, we "afflict our souls," abstaining from food and drink, washing and anointing, leather shoes, and marital relations. When the Temple stood, the service centered on the High Priest's entry into the Holy of Holies and the two goats – one offered to G-d, one sent to carry off Israel's sins. Today the day is spent in synagogue, with five services: Maariv/Kol Nidrei, Shacharit, Musaf, Minchah, and Ne'illah, the closing service at sunset. The holiday Ends at 7:59 PM

Yom Kippur is solemn yet joyful, with confidence in G-d's forgiveness and the hope of being sealed for a good year. Ne'illah concludes with "Hear O Israel... G-d is one" and a single shofar blast, followed by singing, dancing, and a festive after-fast meal.

What Rubs You The Wrong Way?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

Question:

I am so upset I don't know what to do. I am Jewish, but not practicing. I married a non-Jewish man, and Judaism has not been part of our home. Now my worst nightmare has come true. My 19-year-old daughter at university has joined the pro-Palestinian camp. She marches against Israel. She speaks against Jews. It feels like she has turned her back on her family and her heritage. I tried talking to her and it didn't go well. We hardly have any contact now.

My question is not about my older daughter. I feel she is too far gone. But I still have a 15-year-old daughter at home, and I am terrified she will go the same way. I can't let that happen. How can I protect my younger daughter and keep her from rejecting her people?

Response:

Here is what you need to do. Light Shabbat candles. Every Friday evening, on time, without fail. Even if you've never done it before, start now.

You may not have expected this response. Perhaps you were hoping I would give you a book for your daughter to read, or a Jewish group for her to join. But your children don't need more words. They need to see what a Jew looks like. They need a mother who is not just worried anti-antisemitism, but who is pro-Judaism. One small flame on your table will say more to them than a thousand lectures ever could.

Children can sense what their parents truly value. When you light Shabbat candles, when you put a mezuzah on your door, when you study Torah or give charity, you are showing your daughter that Judaism is real to you. No arguments, no debates, just living it. You'll be surprised how impactful that can be. Give a Jewish soul some oxygen and it comes alive.

And here is the secret. Those flames you light on your table may travel further than you think. Even your older daughter, far away with her activist friends, may one day feel the glow of your candles. Don't write her off. Right now her fire is burning in another direction. But a soul never loses its flame. One day, the sparks you ignite in your home may awaken hers as well.

This is not about your older daughter, and it's not about your younger daughter. It's about you, the only person you can control. Light your flame.

Living Moshiach

The Torah-reading of Ha'azinu is referred to as a "song": "Moses spoke... the words of this song..." (Vayeilech 31:30).

The beginning of Ha'azinu describes G-d's continuing love of, and kindness to, Israel. The end of the parshah speaks of the ultimate retribution at the end of days, when Israel shall be redeemed by Moshiach and its glory will be re-established before the whole world. In between, however, there are severe words of rebuke relating to the lapses of Israel's unfaithfulness and the punishment which these precipitate. Yet the whole parshah is called a shirah, a song, something which is normally associated with joy and happiness.

This teaches us that all and any events befalling the Jewish people, including those that appear to us as negative and unwanted, serve but the one single goal of bringing about the true and ultimate redemption. Every event is another rung on the ladder leading to the ultimate and everlasting bliss to be brought about by Moshiach. Thus, even the passages of rebuke and disciplining in our parshah are part of the great song of Israel's history which culminates in the ge'ulah, the final redemption.

Mitzvah Minute

Early on October 7, 2023, as Israel prepared to celebrate Simchat Torah, Hamas terrorists breached the Gaza border by air, land, and sea under cover of heavy rocket fire. The assault killed approximately 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and took roughly 240 hostages. Its brutality, including extreme sexual violence and mutilation, shocked the world. War followed with Hamas and allied terrorist entities, alongside a surge of global antisemitism, leaving many of us asking: what can I do to help?

The Lubavitcher Rebbe taught that every Jew can respond by increasing in Torah observance and mitzvot. A mitzvah is never merely private: it connects us to G-d and to every Jew, everywhere. When one Jew performs a mitzvah in another's merit, the distance between them shrinks.

Tefillin connect mind and heart to G-d; the Rebbe urged Jewish men and boys over thirteen to put them on, especially in times of danger. Shabbat candles, lit each Friday before sunset, symbolize peace and light overcoming darkness. Have your mezuzot checked by a qualified sofer.

Prayer is something everyone can offer, even a few minutes daily for the safety of the Jewish people. Charity turns concern into direct action. Torah study, too, is a source of spiritual strength.

Finally, there is unity itself. October 7 reminded Jews everywhere that we are one people, regardless of how observant we are. Reaching out to a Jewish friend, or inviting someone for Shabbat, strengthens that identity.

The Torah describes the Jewish people rising like a lion, an image Rashi ties to the eagerness with which Jews greet each morning to perform mitzvot. That eagerness is a real response to uncertainty and pain. None of this replaces the effort to protect human life; it is a spiritual response, a way of standing with our brothers and sisters in Israel, even from a great distance.

The Lamplighter

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The Lamplighter is inspired by the works of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

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